

Session 20: Rivers of Life

Key Takeaways

- Rivers and springs are life-giving in the Bible. A river flows out of Eden to water the whole Earth, and rivers flow down from holy mountains in Ezekiel, Psalm 46, and Revelation.
- Rivers, springs, and wells become divine gifts of life in the desert at just the right moment for Hagar, the Israelites, and the Samaritan woman when Jesus gives her living water. The book of Revelation also talks about a river of life flowing down.

The Biblical Earth and Its Foundations in a Modern Worldview

"We have seen that in biblical cosmology, the earth is flat ... and held in place by pillars. We might well ask, 'But what are the pillars standing on?' And the biblical authors never even try to answer that question. Had they done so, they would certainly not have appealed to an eternal regress of pillars upon pillars. Here we may recall the obscure comment from the book of Job: '[God] ... hangs the land upon nothing ([Job 26:7](#))'. The pillars, we might say, are suspended over nothing! So why don't they drop? Because, says Job, God suspends them there ... For the biblical authors, the pillars speak simply of the stability of the earth ... and the earth is utterly dependent on God, not just for its beginning, but at each and every moment of its existence. The universe does not ground itself; it does not explain its own being ... To speak of the earth's pillar is not a primitive physical claim, but a profound metaphysical one."

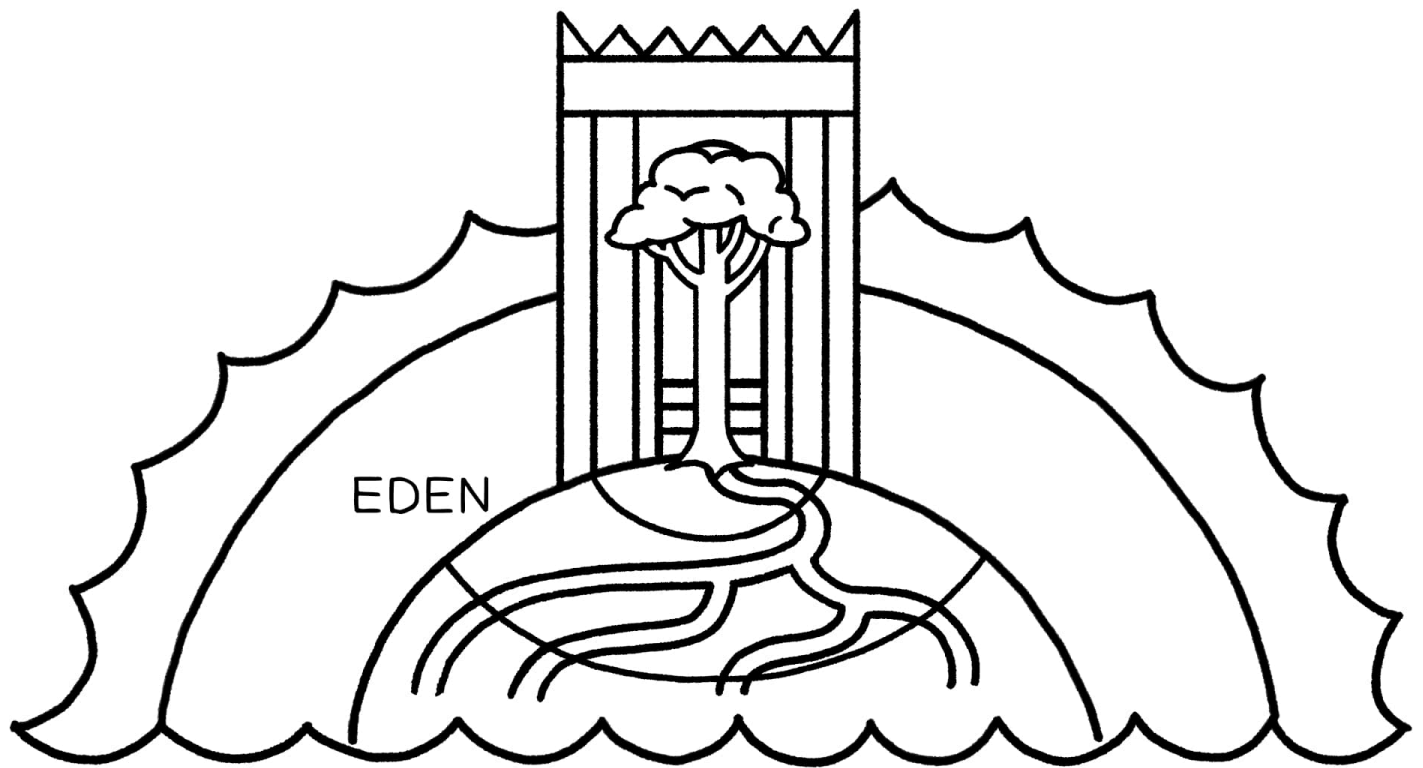
Parry, Robin A. (2014). [*The Biblical Cosmos: A Pilgrim's Guide to the Weird and Wonderful World of the Bible*](#). Cascade Books. 199-200.

Mountains and Rivers in Genesis 1-2

Genesis 1 and 2 depict the emergence of the dry land and Eden as a cosmic mountain where Heaven and Earth overlap. In Genesis 1, God tames the sea, and in Genesis 2, God channels the dark waters below into life-giving waters on the dry land.

- 1:2a: "And the land was wild (Heb. *tohu* / תהו) and waste"
- 1:2b: "And darkness was on the face of the deep abyss (Heb. *tehom* / תהום)"
- 1:2c: "And the wind/spirit of God was hovering on the face of the waters (Heb. *hamayim* / המים)"

These three lines are parallel, matching key terms in order to contrast them. In the place of darkness, we find the opposite, the Spirit of God, through whom the spoken word of God will bring about light.



Tree of Life in the Center of Eden. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).

The double “on the face of the” (על־פְּנֵי) highlights the two parallel terms for waters. These refer to the same reality (i.e., ocean waters) but with two different interpretations.

- 2b: When darkness is present, the waters are threatening and destructive.
- 2c: When God’s Spirit is present, the waters are controlled and can be life-giving.

“Water is commonly conceived [in the Bible and ANE literature] as a symbol of the oppositional forces of life, an ambiguous symbol of life and death ... Water is symbolic of death when it is uncontrolled (too much or too little), and of life when it is controlled, because it provides growth and fertility. This summarizes the movement from Genesis 1:2 to 2:10-14, from the chaotic waters of the dark abyss to the fructifying rivers of Eden. In the Hebrew Bible, this decisive control of the waters is the prerogative of God who is sovereign over death and life ... In this sense, ‘deep abyss’ signifies the negative or threatening aspect of the waters, while ‘the waters’ represent the positive aspect of water under control.”

Morales, Michael (2012). [Tabernacle Prefigured: Cosmic Mountain Ideology in Genesis and Exodus](#). Peeters Publishers. 54-55.

Genesis 2:10-14: The River of Eden

“And a river went out from Eden to water the garden, and from there it was separated and it became four heads.”

1. “The name of the first was Pishon (פִּישׁוֹן = ‘leaper/springer’); it went around the whole land of Havilah where there is gold. And the gold of that land is good. There is the bdellium and onyx stone.”

2. "The name of the second river is Gihon (גיחון = 'gusher'); it goes around all the land of Cush."
3. "The name of the third river is Hideqel; it goes east of Assyria."
4. "And the fourth river is the Euphrates."

Rivers were commonly viewed as having their source in the deep abyss below the land.

Deuteronomy 33:13-16 Instructor's Translation

- ¹³ About Joseph he said: "May the LORD bless his land with the precious dew from heaven above and with the deep abyss (Heb. *tehom*) that lie below;
- ¹⁴ with the best the sun brings forth and the finest the moon can yield;
- ¹⁵ with the choicest gifts of the ancient mountains and the fruitfulness of the everlasting hills;
- ¹⁶ with the best gifts of the earth and its fullness and the favor of him who dwelt in the burning bush. Let all these rest on the head of Joseph, on the brow of the prince among his brothers.

Rivers and Mountains in the Biblical Story

The following are examples of more rivers and mountain imagery in the Bible.

- The Zion temple, the place where Heaven and Earth are one (see cosmic symbolism in [Ps. 46](#), [48](#))
- The future restored temple ([Isa. 2](#); [Ezek. 47](#); [Joel 4](#); [Zech. 14](#))

Jesus as the Temple/Source of the River of Life

- [John chapters 1, 2, 4, 7, 12](#), and [18](#) explore Jesus as the tabernacle, the temple body, and the water of life. We see him exalted and lifted up for his crucified body to provide the water of life to humanity.
- In [Revelation 21-22](#), the new creation is a unified Heaven and Earth as a garden/city/temple on a mountain with a river.

Reflection Question

In a previous session, we learned that the seas represent chaos and are a force that God confronts and defeats. But what connotation do rivers have?